



As a player, he won the Champion of Champions title during the 1985 World Championship in Australia, which India won after defeating Pakistan in the final.

Later in the 1991-92 tour that India lost 0-4, he scored a double ton in Sydney while also keeping a sharp eye on a young Tendulkar. But Shastri wasn't done yet, and as a coach, he shepherded the Indians to defining series triumphs in the 2018-19 and 2020-21 tours of Australia.

The 2020-21 win was epochal as India was considered a team of the walking-wounded, but everyone Shastri blooded as a player became a star. With most of its leading players missing, India still turned up with a touch of steel at Brisbane's Gabba for the fourth and final Test with the series on the line at 1-1.

Be it T. Natarajan or Washington Sundar, Shubman Gill or Shardul Thakur, India had its heroes, and with a calm Ajinkya Rahane at the helm, that 2021 January was tipped to turn

legendary. It did as Rishabh Pant hammered an unbeaten 89 in a tough chase, and India won by three wickets to claim the series at 2-1. Be it Virat Kohli or Rahane, Shastri drew the best from his captains.

The Mumbaikar with an innate Aussie spirit in his demeanour worked his magic and remains the link between Indian cricket of the past and the present. It is a continuity he still fosters as a commentator.

Just as Rohit Sharma (he will miss the first Test in Perth) leads India in the current tour with his fellow late-30s stars in Kohli, R. Ashwin and Ravindra Jadeja, a sense of an ending looms large. Still with vice-captain and spearhead Jasprit Bumrah, and talent like Gill (currently injured), Pant and Yashasvi Jaiswal, under his

Turning point: The Houdini Act by Sourav Ganguly's men in delirious Kolkata, wherein a first-innings deficit and a follow-on were tided past to register a miraculous victory, turbo-charged the India-Australia rivalry. THE HINDU PHOTO LIBRARY

charge, Rohit is looking at perpetuating India's recent dominance against the Aussies. A threat that Pat Cummins and his men want to counter in their backyard with the likes of Usman Khwaja, Steve Smith, Mitchell Starc and Nathan Lyon, itching to reveal their best.

England may be the old enemy, but for these Aussies, India is a clear and present danger. A rivalry awaits its fresh installment, and this is box-office gold.

« A tour of Australia now serves as the yardstick that separates the men from the boys »